



TRUE GRIT

By Nivedita Mukherjee

ideas strike. They cannot be grown or constructed. For 30-year-old Amin Ismail Almel, his Eureka moment came when he was standing in line at his local bank 10 years ago, observing a cashier using a fake currency detector before issuing cash to customers. Intrigued by the machine, he found out that it was being imported from Singapore. Almel moved quickly, quitting his Rs 2,000 per month job as a sales executive, a decision he says was not easy, given his family's dependence on him as the eldest. But, as Larry Ellison says, when you innovate, you've got to be prepared for everyone telling you that you're nuts. Almel

was determined, and his father, who was in the army till he retired in 1992, relented and gave him Rs 5,000 which helped him to buy raw material and set up a workshop in his small flat at Kondhwa in Pune. With the help of a local fabricator in the industrial estate nearby, Almel cast a currency detector model with his own design specifications. By the end of 2000, the first prototype using a Philips ultraviolet lamp was ready at a cost of around Rs 900 which he sold to a military canteen for Rs 3,700.

As people began to flock to see his innovation, Almel, who ironically had to swap an engineering degree for a diploma in electronic instrumentation because of lack of money, realised that the product would not go

Amin ISMAIL ALMEL, 30

INNOVATION

Fake currency detector

COST

Between Rs 3,000 and Rs 3,500

WHAT IT DOES

Helps detect a fake currency note at a lower cost